TOOLBOX TALK — WEEKLY SAFETY METEETING

Millwork | Carpentry | Interior Finishes | Material Handling

WEEK 17

Date: | **Supervisor:**

Project / Job Name:

TOPIC: Clamps & Securing Workpieces

OVERVIEW:

A workpiece that is not secured before a cut or drilling operation is one of the most common contributors to tool injuries on carpentry jobs. When material moves unexpectedly during a cut, the operator's instinctive reaction — grabbing for the piece or the tool — puts hands directly in the

TALKING POINTS — Read to Crew:

1. The rule is simple and absolute: if you are operating a powered cutting or boring tool, the workpiece must be secured. This means clamped to a bench, held in a vise, braced against a stop, or otherwise positively controlled so that it cannot move during the cut. Leaning on it with your knee, holding it with your foot, or assuming it is heavy enough to stay still are not adequate
2. Clamp selection matters. For thin material, a clamp that is too powerful can crush or dent the workpiece. For heavy or thick stock, a light clamp may not hold securely under the force of the tool. Use non-marring pads on finished surfaces, distribute clamping pressure evenly across wide workpieces, and verify that the clamp is fully tightened — not just snugged — before starting the
3. Inspect your clamps before use. Bent arms, cracked castings, stripped threads, and damaged pads are all signs of a clamp that may fail under load. A clamp that releases during a cut can be just as dangerous as no clamp at all because the sudden movement is unexpected. Tag and remove any damaged clamp from service immediately and report it so it can be replaced.
4. When clamping to a work table or sawhorse, make sure the clamp is actually gripping the work table — not just the workpiece to itself — otherwise the whole assembly can slide. Check that the workpiece is positioned so it cannot pivot around the clamp point when the tool engages. For long pieces, use two clamps to prevent rotation.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS — Ask Your Crew:

Q1: Show me how you would set up to cut a 24-inch wide sheet of plywood safely using the tools and clamps we have available.
Q2: Has anyone experienced a workpiece moving during a cut? What happened and what should have been done?

KEY SAFETY POINTS:

- Never hold a workpiece by hand during any powered cutting operation
- Check that all clamps are fully tightened before starting the tool
- Use non-marring pads when clamping finished or delicate surfaces
- Distribute clamp pressure evenly to prevent workpiece distortion
- Inspect clamp threads and jaws — damaged clamps can fail suddenly

Crew sign-in sheet on page 2 — all 30 crew members sign on the following page.

CREW SIGN-IN SHEET

WEEK 17

By signing, I confirm I attended this toolbox talk and understand the topic discussed.

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